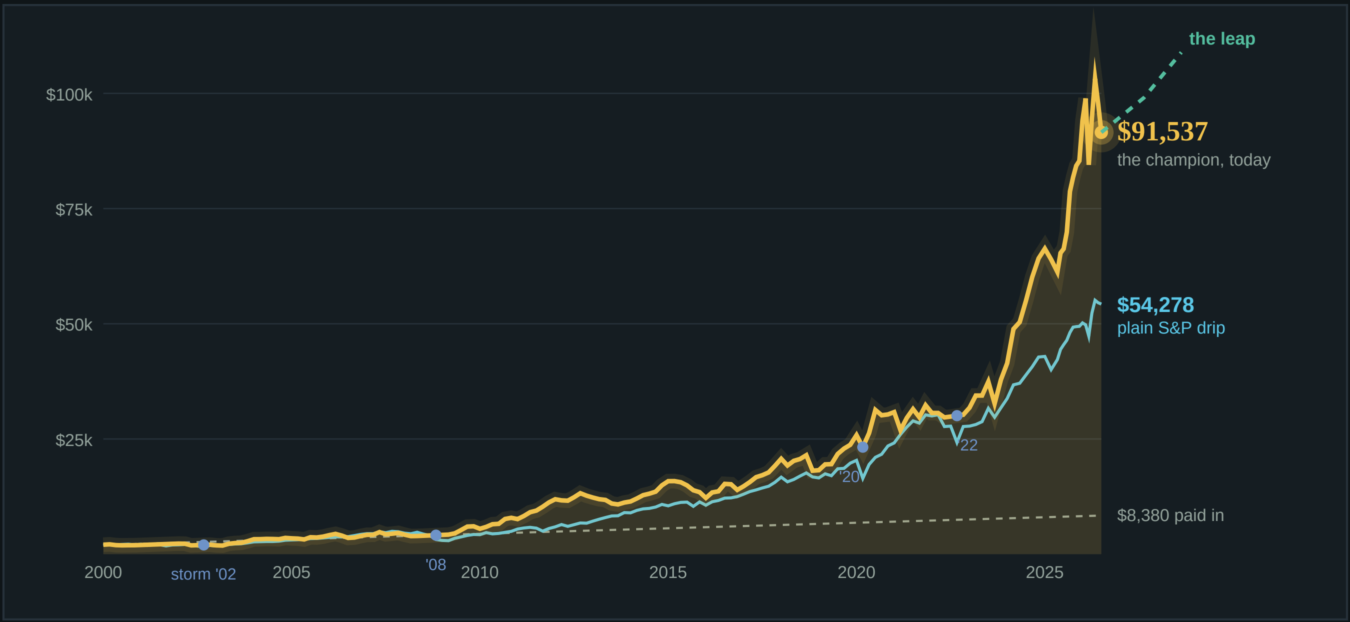
The July Leap

World news in plain money-sense · where a spare $20 goes · the monthly postcard from our robot trader. Data through Friday, July 17 close. Published July 18, 2026.

Hi - welcome to the first Leap. If we haven't met: we keep a house strategy here nicknamed **the champion** - a robot-managed recipe of eight funds (you'll get every ticker on page 4). We test it the honest way: a simulator started it with $2,000 + $20 a month in January 2000 and replayed every real market day since, crashes included, no peeking. That story stands at **$91,537** tonight. July asked it a real question - war headlines, oil up, the hot stocks suddenly cold - and it answered the way we hoped it would: calmly. You don't need our plan, or any plan, to use these pages; borrow the habits with any $20 on any app. We'll be here every month either way.

- the unisona.ai trading desk · *P.S. Our robot's live practice book: $24,997.62 at 2.0× - all three of its tripwires green. Real money stays parked behind the evidence gate, as always.*



The whole flight in one picture: the gold comet is the champion ($8,380 total paid in, dashed line). The cyan line is the same drip into a plain S&P 500 fund (ticker SPY) - $54,278, no robot needed, and still a lovely flight. Four storms, sailed through, dotted in blue.

THE BOARD · FRIDAY'S CLOSING MARKS

SPY $743.29 Fri -1.0% · wk -1.5%	**VIX 18.77** calm is under 20	**10-YR 4.55%** off 4.62% high	**WTI $82+** +10% on the week	**GOLD $4,017** +20% in a year	**FED JUL 28-29** hold expected

The word for July is poise. The champion's balance eased -6.4% as the market rotated - and a dip this size has visited 24 times in 26 years, every one followed, in time, by a new high. So the robot's answer was the calmest sentence it knows: *all gates green, keep cruising, keep dripping.* Poise, practiced.

PART 1 · THE WORLD THIS MONTH, FROM THE TOP

Two big stories - explained like you were away all month

Oil jumped 10% as the Middle East flared up again

THE BACKSTORY

A large share of the world's oil ships through one narrow sea lane - the Strait of Hormuz, between Iran and the Arabian peninsula. Whenever that lane looks risky, oil gets pricier everywhere, because tankers wait, insure, or take the long way round.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED

A June truce between the US and Iran gave way in mid-July: strikes resumed on both sides and far fewer tankers made the passage - about half the usual traffic in a day. Crude climbed above $82 a barrel, its highest in a month, up 10% for the week (CNBC, July 16).

WHY IT TOUCHES YOUR WALLET

Pricier oil seeps into daily life with a lag: the pump first, then flights, shipping, and some grocery prices. It can also make the inflation-watchers at the central bank more cautious about cutting interest rates. Markets themselves stayed remarkably calm - the 'fear index' traders watch (the VIX) reads a mellow 18.8, which is normal-weather territory.

THE CALM MOVE

Storm headlines are not an instruction to do anything. Keeping a cash cushion and letting a monthly auto-investment run is the whole move. Our robot's version of the same idea: it re-checks the weather every minute, ready to glide toward interest-earning cash - and this month it never needed to.

The market's favorite stocks changed seats

THE BACKSTORY

For two years the star performers were computer-chip and AI companies - they powered a huge run. Markets rotate, though: sooner or later money takes profits from the leaders and looks for the next value, and the leaderboard reshuffles. It's regular weather, not an alarm.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED

That rotation arrived in July. Chipmakers cooled sharply - a top supplier's spending plans spooked the group - and the broad S&P 500 index eased about 1.6% for the week. The quiet part: company profits are actually coming in strong - 87% of the early summer earnings reports beat expectations (CNBC and Seeking Alpha, July 16-17).

WHY IT TOUCHES YOUR WALLET

If your savings live in a broad index fund, a week like this barely dents a decades-long plan - and if you were tempted to buy 'the hot stock everyone mentions,' July is why spreading out wins: last month's rocket can be this month's cooldown.

THE CALM MOVE

Own a little of everything and you never have to guess the next favorite. That is the whole trick behind index funds - and behind our robot's eight-ingredient mix, which holds the winners' lane and the calm lanes at once.

Two quieter stories that pay you to know them

The Fed holds interest rates steady - and cash still pays

THE BACKSTORY

The Federal Reserve - 'the Fed' - is America's central bank. Its main dial is the interest rate: turning it up makes borrowing pricier and saving more rewarding (to cool inflation); turning it down does the reverse. Eight times a year, its committee meets and the world watches.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED

The next meeting is July 28-29 and everything points to no change. Inflation readings came in gentler than expected in June, though officials remain watchful with oil rising (Federal Reserve minutes; CNBC, July 8). Bottom line: rates stay where they've been - which is historically decent for savers.

WHY IT TOUCHES YOUR WALLET

This is the friendliest fact in finance right now: boring cash earns real interest again. High-yield savings accounts and money-market funds pay meaningful yields while rates hold - an emergency fund is no longer dead money, it's a small engine.

THE CALM MOVE

Before any investing move, park one: a cushion in a high-yield account is the purchase that buys sleep. Our robot agrees so strongly it's built in - when it de-risks, it parks in interest-earning cash, never under a mattress.

Gold is having a golden year

THE BACKSTORY

Gold is humanity's oldest savings account - no company behind it, no interest paid, just scarcity and trust. People reach for it when they're unsure about everything else, which is why it often (not always) rises when stocks or currencies wobble.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED

It sits near $4,017 an ounce - up about 20% from a year ago even after a breather this month (Trading Economics, July 17). The year's conflicts and inflation worries kept the old anchor in demand.

WHY IT TOUCHES YOUR WALLET

You don't need coins in a drawer to benefit; a small slice of a gold fund inside a mixed portfolio does the same job - it tends to zig when stocks zag, smoothing the ride. The key word is slice: gold pays no interest, so all-in is a bet, not a plan.

THE CALM MOVE

A pinch of gold as seasoning, never the whole meal. In our robot's $20 pour it's $2.80 - enough anchor to steady the boat, never enough to slow the voyage.

The little dictionary - six words this report just used

Index fund - one purchase that buys a tiny slice of hundreds of companies at once. The classic is the S&P 500.

Drip (auto-invest) - the same small amount invested every month, automatically - rain, shine, or headlines.

The Fed - America's central bank. Sets the price of borrowing; meets next July 28-29.

VIX - the market's mood ring - a fear gauge. Under 20 reads calm; July 17 read 18.8.

Momentum - owning a little extra of whatever has already been winning lately.

Dip - how far a balance sits below its best-ever mark. The champion's July dip: 11%.

PART 2 · YOUR NEXT $20

Three lanes - start where you're standing

Twenty dollars a month sounds small; the chart on page 1 is what it looks like grown up. Pick the lane that matches your life today - each one is a complete, respectable answer.

LANE 1 · THE GUARANTEED WIN - claim this first

If any card or loan is charging you double-digit interest, your next $20 earns its best return by shrinking that balance - an instant, sure gain no market can promise. Sorted? Then build the cushion: a few hundred in a high-yield savings account, which finally pays real interest while rates hold. Cushion first, adventure second - every good plan starts here.

LANE 2 · THE ONE-FUND DRIP - the everyone answer

A $20 automatic monthly buy of one broad, low-cost index fund at any major app or broker. Fractional shares mean twenty is plenty; automation means willpower is never invited. This is the cyan line on page 1: $8,380 dripped in since 2000 became $54,278 - through four storms - with zero decisions along the way. Set it on payday and forget it's happening.

LANE 3 · THE CHAMPION'S POUR - for the curious

The robot's own recipe, if you enjoy a richer mix: eight ingredients, poured by target weights, a little extra to whatever's drifted cheap. Here is exactly how it would split a twenty this month:

one twenty, eight tickers - poured automatically, every month

Ticker	Fund	What it is	Fri close	Weight	Of your $20
SPY	The S&P 500	the 500 biggest US companies, one bundle	$743.29	34%	$6.75
TLT	Long US bonds	20+ year loans to the US government - ballast	$84.52	21%	$4.15
QQQ	The tech 100	the Nasdaq's engine room	$695.33	15%	$3.00
GLD	Gold	the ancient anchor, in fund form	$368.41	14%	$2.80
IWM	Small companies	the Russell 2000 - tomorrow's mid-caps	$294.04	5.5%	$1.10
EFA	Rest of the world	big developed markets beyond the US	$103.33	4.6%	$0.90
XMMO	Momentum, mid-size	mid-caps already winning	$157.08	3.7%	$0.75
SPMO	Momentum, large	large-caps in the winners' lane	$143.89	2.9%	$0.55

Lifetime-average recipe, weights rounded (the momentum slices grow as their track record does); closes are Friday 7/17 marks from our live monitor. Fractional shares make every slice buyable with pocket change - and any lane can graduate to the next whenever you're ready.

Lean on, glide past, and where this could fly

Lean on these

THE DRIP ITSELF - Twenty in, every month, rain or shine. Across everything our lab has tested, the steady contribution beats every clever tweak. Level it up when life allows.

BORING BALLAST - Cushion cash that earns interest, bonds, a pinch of gold - the unglamorous pieces are what let you stay invested when headlines shout.

TIME & AUTOMATION - The chart's secret isn't genius - it's 319 straight months of showing up. Automate the showing up and you've automated the hard part.

Glide past these

CHASING THE HOT STOCK - July's coolest lesson: the spring's rockets took the summer's sharpest turn. A broad mix already owns tomorrow's winner - no guessing required.

BORROWING TO INVEST - Leverage looks magic in good months and bites in bad ones. Our robot practices it in a gated paper account; personal money flies best unborrowed.

WATCHING DAILY - A drip plan pays you for patience - every dip your $20 lands in is a discount. The scoreboard worth reading prints monthly. This is it.

THE 24-FOR-24 BADGE. A month like July (-6.4%) has visited the champion's arc 24 times since 2000 - the dot-com winter, 2008, the 2020 flash-storm, the 2022 bear. After all 24, the balance went on to a brand-new high. Number 25 is now on the clock, chasing the May peak of $103,189. History measured, future unwritten - but that is one well-rehearsed bounce.

The leap - if the next years rhyme with the last 26

From the champion's $91,537 + $20/month	by 2031	by 2036
At its measured pace (12.6%/yr)	about $167,000	about $304,000
At the plain index-fund pace (10.0%/yr)	about $148,000	about $241,000
New money added along the way	$1,200	$2,400

Paces are what each line actually measured, 2000-2026; the future keeps its own counsel. The drip, the mix, and patience do the promising here - not the projection.

The dials - for readers who trade

Universe: SPY · QQQ · IWM · EFA · TLT · GLD · XMMO · SPMO, weighted by a shrunk tangency optimizer (per-fund cap 35%), rebalanced with a 0.6%-of-equity no-churn band - about monthly in practice. Exposure dial: gross 0 to 2.0×, set by a streaming brake = 35% volatility target × 6-month trend gate (to cash) × drawdown taper that begins at -30%; idle cash earns T-bill interest. Current stance: gross 2.0×, all three tripwires green, book drawdown -11% vs the -30% taper. A Conservative mode (max 1.0×, never borrows, 12-month trend, wider band, ~1 trade/month) shipped this month for funded balances. Paper only; live capital stays gated on out-of-sample evidence.

Where every number comes from

Champion balances & the chart: unisona.ai walk-forward simulation, 2000-2026, re-run July 17 (real market history, borrowing costs charged, no peeking; monthly path on file). Practice book, ETF closes & robot status: live monitor state, July 18, 17:38 UTC. Market weather: VIX 18.77, July 18 feed. World news: CNBC (July 16-17), Seeking Alpha (July 17), Federal Reserve minutes (July 8), Trading Economics (July 17). Practice mode throughout: simulation + paper account - real dollars wait behind the plan's evidence gate, every real-money decision belongs to a human, and big personal choices deserve a licensed advisor.

Until August - keep the drip alive. - the unisona.ai trading desk